

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1997-03-24

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 february 1997 in which you raise various questions about the use of music
3 and dance at bahá'í centers and we have been asked to respond as follows.

As you may know, in many parts of the world there are certain tribal

4 and traditional dances which are performed in glorification of god, and it
5 is perfectly acceptable for a prayer to be interpreted in the form of move-
6 ment or dance. however, to avoid that such expressions of prayer become
7 gradually ritualized, or that certain gestures and movements become ha-245.4

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247 message from The Universal House of Justice

248 ritual accompaniments to prayers, it is preferable that they not accompany
249 the reciting of words of the prayers. Through the revealed prayers, we seek

communion with god, hence they must be offered with the utmost rever-

250 ence and dignity. each individual bahá'í should be free to pray as he wishes,
251 for there is no set form for prayer except for those few which have special
252 instructions for observance upon their recitation.

in your second question, you ask regarding the performance of drama

253 and cultural dances in bahá'í centers. provided that the underlying themes
254 or stories are noble and that they are performed in a way which does not elicit base
feelings, there is no objection to choreographed dances and

255 dramas, which are intended to illustrate bahá'í principles, being held in

256 a bahá'í center. This same principle would apply to traditional dances or

257 dance movements associated with the expression of a culture. As long as care is
exercised to ensure that the themes of such dances are in harmony

258 with the high ethical standards of the cause and the qualities of dignity and

259 grace are upheld, there is no objection to their use.

with regard to what kind of music can be played at events in bahá'í

260 centers, there is no particular type of music which bahá'ís should or should
261 not use. in this respect, a bahá'í may well be best guided by the words of

bahá'u'lláh in the most holy book, where he makes it clear that music

262 can be both “a means whereby [the soul] may be lifted up unto the realm
263 on high” and “as wings to self and passion,” and warns against allowing
264 music to “cause you to overstep the bounds of propriety and dignity.” in the
265 planning of bahá'í events, it is left to those responsible for the program to
266 determine “the bounds of propriety and dignity” and ensure that the music chosen is
befitting the purpose and solemnity of the occasion, in view of what is most suited to the
country’s culture and customs.

267 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat 246.3

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247 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

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Importance of Upholding the Prohibition

on Alcoholic Beverages

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]